

By Kaveree Bamzai

So, is Ranbir Kapoor playing Rajiv or Rahul Gandhi in *Raajneeti*? “No, I am actually playing Maneka Gandhi,” jokes Kapoor, taking the phone from Prakash Jha as they leave the IIM Bangalore campus, part of the film’s promotional blitzkrieg. Strike that. Kapoor’s actually playing Arjun in the modern-day adaptation of Mahabharata, where Katrina Kaif is Draupadi, Arjun Rampal is her husband Bhim, Ajay Devgan a Dalit Karna and Nana Patekar is Krishna. Situated in a north Indian political dynasty, shot entirely in

Bhopal over 103 days, it has every element trumpeted in breaking news—the industrial-political nexus in Kaif’s character who plays the daughter of a businessman who bankrolls the state’s ruling party, the outsider who returns from the US and is forced to get his hands dirty in Kapoor, and the Dalit who demands his fair share in Devgan. No wonder, laughs Jha, that he’s been getting calls from his politician friends in Delhi, wanting to know when he’s going to show them the movie.

If politics has become a spectacle in recent times, can the spectacle itself be far behind? With politicians exuding movie star aura and exhibiting tabloid-

worthy behaviour, is it any wonder that movies are struggling to keep up? Even the empty glossy products from the YashRaj factory feel obliged to give anti-social behaviour a contemporary legitimacy, as in the pre-liberalisation licence raj for the doings of the *Badmaash Company* who enjoy exploiting loopholes in customs duties to make money. Mani Ratnam is the master of this personal-is-political genre. So it is not surprising that the other auteur movie this summer, *Raavan*, which comes two weeks after *Raajneeti*, is an update on the Ramayana. Abhishek Bachchan plays the “*dus maathewala, sau naamwala*” Beera Munda, a tribal leader who abducts Ragini (Aishwarya Rai Bachchan), after her husband, Dev, a high caste police officer, kills his sister. Beera, of whom a song says you cannot ask his birthplace or his caste (*Janam na poochhe/Jaat na poochhe*), falls in love with

Epic SEASON

A modern-day Mahabharata confronts a retelling of the Ramayana in a summer of edgy blockbusters

